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COMMUNITY CORNER

PARSHAS BEHAALOSECHA בהעלתך



SHABBOS STARTS:

8:07 PM
(18 MINUTES)

SHABBOS ENDS:

9:16 PM
(50 MINUTES)

TZAIS HAKOCHAVIM:

9:36 PM
(72 MINUTES)

Editor-in-chief: Doni Stern

Made possible by contributing writers throughout our community.

STORY OF THE WEEK By: Zechariah Lipitz



In the olden days, the Jews of Germany were known for their highly organized social and community structure. Being chosen for a post in one of these communities was a badge of honor, as it signified having been approved by several screening committees. And once a candidate was selected, his authority and influence over communal life was considerable. The selection process for religious leaders was equally stringent. Being the rabbi of a German Jewish community was a prestigious position, and there was much competition. Rabbi Refael Cohen, the Rav of Pinsk, was one of the leading Torah authorities of his generation. At the age of ten he had been accepted into the famous yeshiva of the "She'agat Aryeh," and at 19 he already headed the yeshiva. Before Pinsk, he had served as Rav in Posna and Minsk. It was therefore not surprising when he was asked to serve as rabbi of Hamburg, one of the most important Jewish communities in Germany. The rabbi set off for Hamburg to meet with its leaders and begin the official process of appointment.

By that time, the winds of the Enlightenment had already begun to blow across Germany. The stated aim of its proponents was the "modernization" of Judaism, while retaining its age-old traditions. In fact, however, its underlying goal was the removal of all barriers separating Jew and non-Jew, and the ultimate assimilation of the Jewish people into the family of nations. Rabbi Refael, who hailed from the "backwaters" of Lithuania, had never met any Maskilim, as they were called, and the whole idea was foreign to him. Moses Mendelssohn was one of the main proponents of the Enlightenment then living in Berlin. To many German Jews, he was a visionary whose opinions and "Weltanschauung" greatly influenced their own. Among those who regarded him in this light were several of the community leaders of Hamburg, who were now in charge of appointing a rabbi. Their ideal candidate would be knowledgeable in Torah, yet "progressive" enough to keep up with current fashions and trends.

When Rabbi Refael appeared before the selection committee, they were impressed by his obvious scholarship and wisdom. His personal views and beliefs, however, remained unknown. The board decided that the best person to judge Rabbi Refael's character would be Moses Mendelssohn himself. Rabbi Refael was told only that if he wished to conclude the appointment process as quickly as possible, he must travel to Berlin to meet with one of the greatest Jewish thinkers of all time, Moses Mendelssohn. If he received his recommendation, the position of Rabbi was his.

Rabbi Refael, in his naiveté, assumed that he was going to meet a Torah sage, and set off for Berlin. In the meantime, the board sent an urgent letter to Moses Mendelssohn explaining the situation and asking him to assess the moral fiber of the Lithuanian rabbi. Was he truly qualified to be Rav of the "progressive" community of Hamburg? Rabbi Refael walked into Moses Mendelssohn's home and saw the "Torah Sage" sitting at his desk with his head uncovered, rifling through a Hebrew Bible. He was so astonished that he was momentarily speechless. In addition to his shock, he also felt as if he had been deliberately deceived and misled.

When Mendelssohn looked up and greeted his visitor with "Shalom," Rabbi Refael responded with a quote from Isaiah, "There is no peace, says the L-rd." How could they have sent me to a heretic?" he thundered. "I would rather be reduced to begging than have to obtain the recommendation of someone who sits and learns our holy Torah with an uncovered head!" With that, he turned on his heels and left.

Before he got back to Hamburg, however, a letter arrived from Moses Mendelssohn apprising the board of his findings: "I did not have time to assess the character of the Lithuanian rabbi," he wrote, "for as soon as he saw me, he called me a heretic and stormed out. Why? Because my head was uncovered as I was looking into a Bible. He refused to accept any recommendation from me and declared that he'd rather be a beggar than need my approval."

The members of the board assumed that Moses Mendelssohn was telling them that Rabbi Refael was obviously unqualified for the position. But no! The end of the letter contained a surprise: "I therefore recommend that you appoint him as Rav, for he is a man of truth. I am sure that such a person would never be anything less than completely impartial, even if a sword were suspended over his throat..."

In the end Rabbi Refael was appointed as Rav of Hamburg and served in that capacity for many years. Throughout his life he continued to be a staunch opponent of the Enlightenment and of Mendelssohn himself, whose recommendation secured his job in the first place.

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NOW AVAILABLE IN EVERGREEN UPTOWN!

PARSHA QUESTION By: Gavriel Grodsko

How old were the Leviim who served in the Ohel Moed?

Stay tuned for the answer in the next Community Corner issue

Answer to last weeks parsha question:

Q. Which three activities were forbidden to the Nazir?

A. Haircuts, abstaining from wine, coming in contact with a dead body.

THIS WEEK IN JEWISH HISTORY By: Avi Hirsch



The Israeli Air Force bombarded a residential neighborhood near Qasr al-Qubba in Cairo on July 15, 1948, during the international phase of the 1948 Palestine war. The attack was carried out during the breaking of the fast of Ramadan and killed 30 civilians and destroyed many homes. It led to an angry march on the Jewish quarter. Before the establishment of the State of Israel, the Haganah had ordered three Boeing B-17 Flying Fortress planes from the United States through US Mahal operative Al Schwimmer. The heavy bomber planes were prepared for combat by Mahal recruit Ray Kurtz. They were acquired during the truce and smuggled from Czechoslovakia in violation of an arms embargo. The 69 Squadron of the Israeli Air Force was flying the planes, which were ordered to strike Egyptian targets on the way from Czechoslovakia. The air operation attempted to bomb King Farouq's Abdeen Palace. One plane went to Cairo but failed to hit the palace. The bombing struck a residential neighborhood during Ifar, killing 30 Egyptians and striking a rail line. According to Al-Ahram the following day, the bombardment happened at 7:55 pm. The two other planes were supposed to strike el-Arish but bombed Rafah instead. The bombardment killed 30 Egyptians, struck a rail line, and led to an angry march on a Jewish quarter in Cairo. The bombardment raised morale in Tel Aviv. In the heightened tensions following the attack, a series of bombings targeted Jewish businesses and institutions in Cairo, including the Cicurel Department Store of the Cicurel family. The Cicurels were a prominent Sephardic Jewish family in Egypt throughout the first half of the 20th century, best known for the elite department store chain bearing their family name.

Moreno Cicurel, the family patriarch, emigrated from Turkey in the latter half of the 19th century. Other members of the family remained in Smyrne until the beginning of 20th century and then migrated to the USA (San Francisco) and to France. Moreno Cicurel established Les Grands Magasins Cicurel at the turn of the century. His three sons helped grow the business to prosperity and acclaim following his death.

The Cicurels were initially able to survive the growing anti-Semitism in Egypt following the creation of Israel. But ultimately, the government sequestered the business and forced its sale. The family left Egypt and dispersed across Europe and South America. Today the stores remain, but only as a shell, devoid of their former grandeur.

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